

Supported vs. Unsupported Claims

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Decide which claims are justified by the source evidence and which claims go beyond what the evidence can support.

2. What this skill means

A supported claim matches the evidence in scope, certainty, and meaning. An unsupported claim may sound reasonable but add a cause, prediction, generalization, or level of certainty that the source does not establish.

3. Do not confuse it with

"The pilot suggests the schedule may reduce absences" is different from "The schedule proves absences will fall everywhere." Watch for words such as may, some, during the pilot, and at this site.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "Which claim is supported?", "Which statement goes beyond the evidence?", "Which revision is most defensible?", or "Why is this conclusion too strong?"

5. Repeatable method

- List what the evidence actually shows.
- Mark scope words: who, where, when, and how many.
- Mark certainty words: may, suggests, proves, always, never.
- Reject answers that add a new cause, prediction, or universal claim.
- Choose the narrowest conclusion that fully fits the evidence.

6. Worked example

During an eight-week trial in one department, absences fell from 28 to 21 and completed work remained stable.

Question: Which conclusion is best supported?

Reasoning: The evidence supports a limited statement about this trial, not a universal claim about every workplace or permanent productivity gains.

Best answer: The trial suggests the schedule may reduce absences in this department without reducing completed work.

7. Common traps

- Turning "may" into "will."
- Generalizing from one group to all groups.
- Adding a cause the source never isolated.

8. Diagnostic help

- If your answer uses "always," "proves," or "everyone," compare that strength with the source wording.
- If your answer mentions people or places not studied, you probably widened the scope.
- If you added a reason for a result, check whether the source actually tested that cause.

9. Quick check

A three-month pilot at one branch reduced average waiting time by 11 percent.

What is a supported claim?

Check yourself: The pilot suggests the new process may reduce waiting time at that branch; it does not prove every branch will see the same result.